

The Startup Delusion Index

Who's charging tomorrow's price for yesterday's growth?

326.8×

The highest asking multiple in the dataset — for a startup that has made \$81 in its entire lifetime, and is currently down 96%.

1,000

startups scanned

262

listed for sale

\$35K

median asking price

How We Built the Lie Detector

Delusion Score = Ask Percentile – Growth Percentile

For every startup listed for sale, we rank it two ways: how aggressive its asking multiple is versus every other listing, and how much its revenue and MRR actually grew last month. Subtract the growth rank from the ask rank. Positive means they're asking for more than their growth backs up — negative means the business is quietly underpriced.

Across the whole marketplace, asking price and growth are barely related — correlation of just **–0.14**. Sellers are pricing on vibes, not fundamentals.

LOW GROWTH · HIGH ASK

DELUSIONAL

Rolely (Education) — \$4,000 ask at 326.8×, on \$81 of lifetime revenue, down 95.8% last month.

HIGH GROWTH · HIGH ASK

CERTIFIED GENIUS

DodgePrint (SaaS) — \$1.2M ask at 8.8×, backed by real MRR growth of roughly 57%.

LOW GROWTH · LOW ASK

JUST VIBING

imposter · ai (Games) — \$300K ask at 0.9×, 0% growth. Fittingly named.

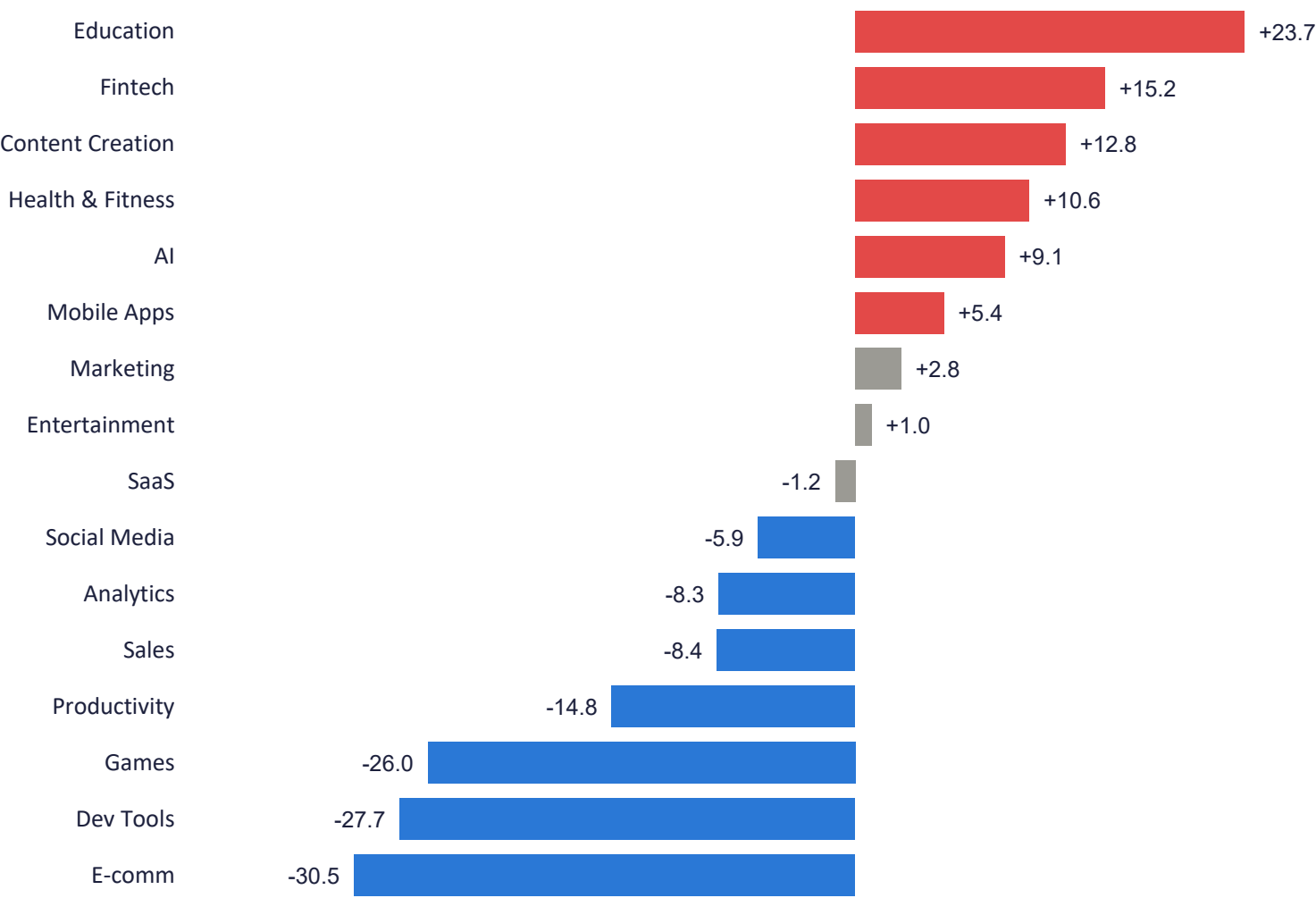
HIGH GROWTH · LOW ASK

HIDDEN GEM

Linkedit (Sales) — \$5,000 ask at 0.2×, +105% revenue and +90% MRR growth.

The Delusion Leaderboard

16 categories with enough listings to judge — ranked by asking price minus what growth actually justifies



MOST DELUDED

Education

+23.7 pts — asking prices that outrun growth by the widest margin (n=10)

MOST HONEST

E-commerce

-30.5 pts — growing faster than their modest asking prices admit (n=6)

Bars need at least 4 listings to make the board.

Hall of Fame (and Shame)

Two real listings on the same marketplace, on the same day, with wildly different relationships to reality

MOST DELUDED LISTING

Rolely

Education · Resume builder

\$4,000

asking price

326.8×

revenue multiple

\$81

lifetime revenue, ever

"Someone wants \$4K for a resume tool that has made \$81. Ever."

-95.8%

revenue last 30 days

MOST HONEST LISTING

Linkeddit

Sales · Reddit marketing platform

\$5,000

asking price

0.2×

revenue multiple

+105%

revenue, last 30 days

"Growing like a rocket. Priced like a garage sale."

+90%

MRR, last 30 days

Bonus plot twist: pitches that mention "AI" ask for LESS (median 1.8×, n=82) than plain ones (median 2.4×, n=180). But say "all-in-one" — multiples jump to 5.6×, more than double the marketplace norm (n=11).

So What Do We Do With This?

1

Growth and asking price are basically strangers.

Correlation across the whole marketplace: -0.14 . Most sellers are pricing on hope, not on their own numbers.

2

Education, Fintech, and Content Creation talk the biggest game.

Their listings ask for premiums their growth doesn't come close to backing up — while E-commerce and Dev Tools quietly undersell themselves.

3

If you're buying: check the math before the memo.

A huge multiple on tiny revenue isn't a business — it's a bet. “AI” in the pitch doesn't raise the price. “All-in-one” does.